69 Learning a language

1 Basic vocabulary

Complete the dialogues with these words and expressions:

second language	bilingual	strong accent
mother-tongue	native speaker	

1. So, Sandy, what language do you speak in Hong Kong?
   > Well, of course, Chinese is my . . . . . , but for almost everyone, English is spoken as a . . . . . .
2. So, Sven, you've been learning English for ten years. That's a long time.
   > I suppose it is, but I want to keep learning until I can hold a conversation like a . . . . . .
3. Where did you learn to speak such good Spanish, Mary?
   > Well my dad's Spanish and I went to school in Madrid until I was nine so I'm basically . . . . . .
4. I find it very difficult to understand Maggie when she speaks quickly.
   > Well, she comes from Liverpool and she's got quite a . . . . I'm sure you'll get used to it.

2 Typical classroom questions

Use these words to complete the questions below:

pronounce	say	difference
mean	spell	plural

1. How do you . . . . . 'coche' in English?
2. What does 'rush' . . . . . ?
3. What's the . . . . . between 'for' and 'since'?
4. How do you . . . . . this word?
5. How do you . . . . . 'headache'?
6. What's the . . . . . of 'calf'?

Now match the questions to the answers below:

a. It's h-e-a-d-a-c-h-e.
b. 'For' answers the question 'How long' and since answers the question 'When?'.
c. It means *go very quickly.*
d. Calves.
e. Car.
f. You pronounce it /bau/ like 'now'.

3 Learning and practising

Use the correct form of these verbs to complete the text below:

practise	study
say	improve
pick up	make
hold	do

When I first started learning English ten years ago, I could hardly (1) . . . . . a word – 'hello,' 'goodbye', 'thank you' was just about it! I went to classes two evenings a week and I was surprised at how quickly I (2) . . . . . progress. During the course we learned lots of vocabulary and (3) . . . . . grammar rules. The thing I enjoyed most was being able to (4) . . . . . speaking with the other students in my class.

After two years I went to England to a language school. It was in Cambridge. I (5) . . . . . a three-week course at a very good school and I stayed with a local family. It was a fantastic experience and I (6) . . . . . a lot of new language from speaking with my host family and with other students from all over the world. I really (7) . . . . . my pronunciation as well. When I got back to Spain, I was so much more confident. I could actually (8) . . . . a conversation with my teacher in English.

Now complete these whole expressions from the text. The first one has been done for you.

9. I could hardly say a word.
10. I made . . . . . .
11. We studied . . . . . .
12. I enjoyed being able to . . . . . speaking with the other students.
13. I did . . . . . at a language school.
14. I picked up . . . . . .
15. I really improved my . . . . . .
16. I could actually hold . . . . . .

You can study English with a teacher in a group or you can have private or one-to-one lessons.

4 Grammar words

Choose one of the words in green from this text as an example of each part of speech:

A commuter was extremely annoyed because his morning train was late again, so he decided to go and complain to the station manager. "I pay a lot of money for my ticket and this is the third time this week that my train has been late. What's the point of having a timetable if the trains are never on time?" he asked. The manager thought for a moment, then said: "Well, how would you know that the trains were late if there wasn't a timetable?"

1. main verb . . . . . .
2. adverb . . . . . .
3. modal verb . . . . . .
4. auxiliary verb . . . . . .
5. countable noun . . . . . .
6. definite article . . . . . .
7. uncountable noun . . . . . .
8. indefinite article . . . . . .
9. adjective . . . . . .
10. preposition . . . . . .
11. pronoun . . . . . .
12. conjunction . . . . . .

5 Language terms

Match the language terms below with the highlighted words and phrases in the sentences:

a proverb	a gerund
a phrasal verb	an idiom
a collocation	the 'to' infinitive

1. I decided to do a conversation class.
2. Let me look it up in my dictionary.
3. I really enjoy trying to speak English.
4. "Too many cooks spoil the broth."
5. I'm a bit out of my depth in the advanced class.
6. Please correct me if I make a mistake.

6 What teachers say

Use the correct form of these expressions to complete the sentences:

do the exercises	correct	practise
listen carefully	repeat	hand in

1. I'm only going to play the tape once so . . . . . .
2. OK everybody, ... after me: "I think I'll call back later."
3. Remember to . . . . . some of what you've learned today outside the classroom.
4. I want you to . . . . . on page 78 for homework and don't forget you need to . . . . . your essays on Friday.
5. I'm not going to . . . . . every mistake you make. That would not be helpful.

Now use the correct form of these expressions:

make mistakes	write it down	revise
rub it out	look it up	

6. If you're not sure what something means, ... in your dictionary.
7. Whenever you hear a new word that you think is important, ... in your notebook.
8. Don't worry about . . . . . . The important thing is to try to communicate.
9. Write the answers in pencil. Then if you get one wrong, you can . . . . . and do it again.
10. Remember there's a test tomorrow. So, spend a bit of time . . . . . this evening.